BOOKKEEPING THAT DOESN'T SUCK

Quick-Start Guide — Small Business Money Tracker

What you bought: one spreadsheet that tracks every dollar in and out of your business, then does the math for you — profit, profit margin, your tax set-aside, mileage deductions, and a tax-time rollup. It works in **Excel** and **Google Sheets** (in Sheets: File → Import → Upload, and it converts clean).

The 3 steps (this is the whole system)

1. **Log it.** Money comes in → add a row on **MONEY IN**. Money goes out → add a row on **MONEY OUT**. Pick the category from the dropdown. Thirty seconds, same day, while you still remember what it was for.
2. **Check the DASHBOARD.** It answers the only question that matters — *did we actually make money?* — and shows your tax set-aside in dollars.
3. **At tax time, hand over the TAX TIME tab.** It rolls the year into plain-English tax lines and works out your quarterly estimated payments. Print it or send the file to your accountant.

> **The tax set-aside (the feature the plain templates don't have).** Most small businesses don't go broke on slow months — they go broke in April, when the tax bill lands and the money's already spent. So: open the Dashboard, set your set-aside percentage once (orange cell — 25% is a common starting point; ask your accountant for YOUR number). From then on, the Dashboard always shows the dollar amount of your profit that belongs to the tax man. That money is spent. It's not yours. Leave it in the account.

The tabs, one line each

- **START HERE** — the instructions, inside the file.
- **DASHBOARD** — year at a glance: money in, money out, profit, margin, DON'T SPEND THIS, this month vs last month, top 5 expenses, month-by-month chart.
- **MONEY IN / MONEY OUT** — the two logs. 200 pre-formatted rows each, totals at the bottom. The expense log has a Tax-Deductible? Y/N column.

- **PROFIT & LOSS** — the scoreboard, auto-built from the logs with a monthly breakdown. Change the year at the top and everything follows.
- **TAX TIME** — Schedule-C-style rollup in plain English, quarterly payment helper with due dates, and a sales-tax collected tracker.
- **MILEAGE** — date, where/why, miles. The sheet prices your deduction at the IRS rate — the rate sits in an orange cell on that tab; check the current IRS standard mileage rate and update it.
- **BUDGET** — your planned monthly spend per category (orange column) vs what you actually spent. Overspends turn red.

Before you start: delete the examples

The logs come pre-filled with example rows from a small contracting business's January, so you can watch the Dashboard and P&L working first. When you're ready, select those example rows on MONEY IN, MONEY OUT and MILEAGE, delete them, and start with your own numbers. All totals and formulas keep working.

Two rules that keep the sheet honest

- **Grey cells are formulas.** Don't type in them. The few things you set live in **orange cells**: the year (Profit & Loss), the set-aside % (Dashboard), the IRS mileage rate (Mileage), and your budgets (Budget).
- **One vehicle rule:** for car costs, pick fuel/repairs on MONEY OUT *or* mileage on the MILEAGE tab — never both for the same costs. Your accountant will ask.

This spreadsheet is a bookkeeping tool, not tax advice. Deduction rules, mileage rates and estimated-tax requirements change — confirm your numbers with a tax professional. © Ren Delivers. For use in your own business; please don't resell or redistribute the file.